

The Sūtra of the Palace of Āṭānāṭā

Āṭānāṭiya Sūtra · Toh 33 · Derge Kangyur

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The Āṭānāṭiya Sūtra, known in Tibetan as the Sūtra of the Palace of Āṭānāṭā (Lcang lo can gyi pho brang gi mdo), is a protective discourse in which the four great kings — the guardian deities of the cardinal directions — visit the Buddha on Vulture Peak Mountain and recite a powerful dhāraṇī intended to ward off malevolent spirits and safeguard Buddhist practitioners. The text belongs to the genre of rakṣā or protection literature, drawing on the cosmology of yakṣas, gandharvas, kumbhāṇḍas, and nāgas who serve under the four kings and whose names are invoked throughout the sūtra. It is one of the most widely used ritual protection texts in Buddhist traditions across Asia, recited to this day as a safeguard against harm. This sūtra is Toh 33 in the Kangyur, where it is classified among the general sūtra literature.

Thus may it be. In the language of India: Āṭānāṭiya Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra of the Palace of Āṭānāṭā. With reverence I bow to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak Mountain. Then the four great kings were abiding there, guarding the four directions together with many troops of yakṣas, many troops of gandharvas, many troops of kumbhāṇḍas, and many troops of nāgas. They abode in groups in each of the four directions. They abode protecting the four directions. Coming in the night, they illuminated only Vulture Peak Mountain with their multicolored radiance, and then went to where the Blessed One was. Having paid homage to the Blessed One, they took their places to one side. Among those yakṣas as well, those who paid homage to the Blessed One took their places to one side. Those who presented their respects to the Blessed One and then inquired of him, as is fitting, about matters of substance and matters without substance — those too took their places to one side. Those who paid homage to the Blessed One with palms joined took their places to one side. Those who exchanged names and examined their lineages took their places to one side. Those who said nothing at all took their places to one side.

Having taken their places to one side, the great king Vaiśravaṇa then spoke to the Blessed One as follows: Venerable One, there are certain wicked yakṣas who have no faith in the Blessed One, and there are certain wicked yakṣas

who have come to have faith in the Blessed One. There are certain middling yakṣas who have no faith in the venerable Blessed One, and there are certain middling yakṣas who have come to have faith in the venerable Blessed One. There are certain lesser yakṣas who have no faith in the venerable Blessed One, and there are certain lesser yakṣas who have come to have faith in the venerable Blessed One. What, venerable Blessed One, is the reason why certain yakṣas have no faith in the venerable Blessed One? The venerable Blessed One has taught the Dharma of abandoning the taking of life, the Dharma of abandoning taking what is not given, the Dharma of abandoning sexual misconduct, the Dharma of abandoning false speech, and the Dharma of abandoning the drinking of intoxicating liquor. Now those yakṣas who take no delight in abandoning the taking of life, who take no delight in abandoning taking what is not given, who take no delight in abandoning sexual misconduct, who take no delight in abandoning false speech, and who take no delight in abandoning the drinking of intoxicating liquor — those beings have become displeased and unwilling. Furthermore, the venerable Blessed One has had all the śrāvakas who exist enter the path of remote forests and wilderness, abiding in lying down and sitting in dependence upon solitude. They dwell in seclusion, free from noise and clamor, undisturbed by gatherings. Individual renunciants (śramaṇas) dwell in harmony with one another. And in such places the abodes of the wicked yakṣas are found. Those who have no faith in the word of the Blessed One — in order that they may come to have faith, I request that the venerable Blessed One receive instruction in this matter: that the Palace of Āṭānāṭā be requested to provide protection, so that monks and nuns, male and female lay practitioners may be guarded, sheltered, kept free from harm, at ease, and well established. The Blessed One gave his consent by remaining silent.

Then the great king Vaiśravaṇa, knowing that the Blessed One had given his consent, at that time spoke thus: Let there be protection by the Palace of Āṭānāṭā!

To the one endowed with eyes, endowed with glory,
To the All-Seeing, I pay homage.

To the one with the uṣṇīṣa who shows compassion to all beings,
I pay homage.

To the one who, burned with longing for the helpless, protects them all,
I pay homage.

To the one who vanquishes the hosts of māra and destroys cyclic existence,

I pay homage.

To the golden sage endowed with brahmic splendor,

I pay homage.

To Kāśyapa, who brings sentient beings to liberation,

I pay homage.

To the glorious son of the Śākya, of the solar lineage,

I pay homage.

To the one who liberates from all suffering, who teaches the Dharma most excellently,

who has become truly worldly-wise, who sees things just as they are — among those, there is no slander, and there is great fearlessness.

Whoever pays homage to Gautama brings benefit to gods and humans alike.

Endowed with knowledge and feet, he is great fearlessness itself.

The great orb of the sun rises and sets in one and the same place.

Where the sun has set, that is night.

Where the sun has risen, that is called day.

The essence of the water of the deep and fathomless ocean is excellent.

Born there in such a manner, he is like the essence of the ocean's water.

Here, to the beings of the eastern quarter, this is declared:

The great king of renowned fame, guardian of that quarter,

lord of the gandharvas (celestial musicians), whose name is the King Dhṛtarāṣṭra —

together with his retinue of gandharvas, he delights in song and dance.

His many sons all bear one and the same name:

they are called Indra, endowed with power, and they number ninety-one.

They, upon seeing the Buddha, the Buddha of the solar lineage, bow from afar to the great fearless one.

I pay homage to you, O man of universal knowledge.

I pay homage to you, O supreme being.

Non-humans pay homage to you who always speak of virtue — they listen to this always.

Therefore, with that in mind, this is declared:

Pay homage to the Victor Gautama!

I pay homage to the Victor Gautama.

I pay homage to the Buddha Gautama, endowed with knowledge and feet.

Whoever speaks falsehood, who has slander as flesh upon his back,

who is attached to taking life, and who destroys all people —

Here, to the beings dwelling in the southern quarter, this is proclaimed:

The great king of renowned fame, guardian of that quarter,

lord of the kumbhāṇḍas (a class of spirits), whose name is Virūḍhaka —

together with his retinue of kumbhāṇḍas, he delights in song and dance.

His many sons all bear one and the same name:

they are called Indra, endowed with power, and they number ninety-one.

They, upon seeing the Buddha, the Buddha of the solar lineage,

bow from afar to the great fearless one.

I pay homage to you, O man of universal knowledge.

I pay homage to you, O supreme being.

Non-humans pay homage to you who always speak of virtue —

they listen to this always.

Therefore, with that in mind, this is declared:

Pay homage to the Victor Gautama!

I pay homage to the Victor Gautama.

I pay homage to the Buddha Gautama, endowed with knowledge and feet.

Wherever the great solar orb rises and to wherever it moves —

there it becomes day, and day it is called.

Where the sun has set, that is proclaimed to be night.

The essence of the water of the deep and fathomless ocean is excellent.

Born there in such a manner, he is like the essence of the ocean's water.

Here, to the beings of the western quarter, this is declared:

The great king of renowned fame, guardian of that quarter,

lord of the nāgas, whose name is Virūpākṣa —

together with his retinue of nāgas,

he delights with song and dance.

His sons, numerous as they are,

are all heard to bear a single name:

they are called Powerful, endowed with strength.

These number ninety-one.

They, upon seeing the Buddha —

the Buddha, kinsman of the sun —

bow from afar

to the one utterly free from fear.

"Homage to you, the man who knows all things!

Homage to you, the supreme man!
Homage to you who ever proclaim what is virtuous,
you, the superhuman ones!
Ever they listen to this."

Therefore it is thus proclaimed:
Pay homage to the Victor Gautama!
I pay homage to the Victor Gautama,
endowed with knowledge and feet.
I pay homage to the Buddha Gautama.

Now, concerning the northern quarter, there is Śrī Kuśa, the pleasing mountain
of Sumeru, beautiful to behold.

The people born there possess nothing they call their own.

They sow no seeds, and they do no plowing;
without toil, fruit ripens,
and the people enjoy it fully.

It is huskless, ungathered, utterly pure,
fragrant rice that bears excellent fruit.

From the milk of the rice they churn,
and likewise cook it and enjoy it.

Mounting a single-footed ox,
they travel to country and region.

Riding a single-footed beast,
they go to country and region.

Mounting the conveyance of women,
they ride to country and region.

Mounting the conveyance of men,
they go to country and region.

Mounting the conveyance of maidens,
they ride to country and region.

Mounting the conveyance of youths,
they go to country and region.

Mounting all those conveyances,
they travel in every direction alike.

The sovereign king is without peer.

Dwelling upon elephant conveyance and horse conveyance,
upon divine conveyance,

in fine mansions and in pleasure grounds,
the great king endowed with renown —
his perfectly accomplished city
abides in the stainless sky.

There are the cities of Śālavatī and Kuśa,
the city on the far side of Kuśa,
the city of Nāṭā and
the city of Kusiṭa beyond.

In the northern quarter all is abundant;
hosts of many people dwell there.

Ninety-nine cities in the sky,
and the royal palace Śālavatī.

Furthermore, the great sage
and the great king Virūpākṣa —
Viśāṇā is the name of that royal palace.

Therefore the great king, son of Vaiśravaṇa,
is called Virūpākṣa.

Individually distinct, serene, each with its own luster and splendor, courageous
and endowed with strength — these are the names meaning "king endowed
with power."

The earth there is rich with essence.

In that place the clouds send down rain.

There is a small pond called Bhagalatī,
where the hosts of yakṣas dwell together.

There, too, the fruit of trees is ever-present.

Various birds dwell together there:

peacocks and cranes cry out,

cuckoos nest in flocks,

the śaṅkhatara birds call out,

and there too the ngurpa,

the gonmo, and the forest crow

dwell in the woodland pond.

The mynah and the calling mountain bird give voice;

the white daṇḍamāṭa bird

adorns it beautifully at all times.

The pond of King Virūpākṣa is ever lovely.

This is the region of the northern quarter,

and the people proclaim it thus.

The guardian of that quarter,
the great king endowed with renown,
lord of the yakṣas —

this one's name is Virūpākṣa.

He, together with his retinue of yakṣas,
delights with song and dance.

His sons, numerous as they are,
are all heard to bear a single name:

Endowed with power, they are called Indra (Śakra),
and their number is ninety-one.

They too, upon seeing the buddha
and the buddha who is kinsman of the sun,
bow from afar
to the great one freed from fear.

"We salute you, O man of perfect knowledge!

We salute you, O supreme among men!

To you who ever proclaim what is good,
we non-humans offer homage.

We ever listen to this teaching,
and therefore we declare it thus:

Pay homage to the Victor Gautama!

We pay homage to the Victor Gautama!

Endowed with knowledge and with feet of virtue,
we salute the buddha Gautama!"

Let the great sages, together with the willow palace, guard this place. May
monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen be protected, concealed from harm, free
from injury, and dwell in comfort and well-being.

Whatever great sages are accompanied by monks, or accompanied by nuns,
or accompanied by laymen, or accompanied by laywomen — let all of them
bear in mind that this willow palace guards and fully protects them here.

The non-humans who are its retinue are as follows: male yakṣas, female
yakṣas, yakṣa sons, yakṣa daughters, great yakṣa ministers, yakṣa attendants,
and yakṣa servants; male gandharvas (dri za), female gandharvas, gandharva
sons, gandharva daughters, great gandharva ministers, gandharva attendants,

and gandharva servants; male kumbhāṇḍas (grulbum), female kumbhāṇḍas, kumbhāṇḍa sons, kumbhāṇḍa daughters, great kumbhāṇḍa ministers, kumbhāṇḍa attendants, and kumbhāṇḍa servants; male nāgas, female nāgas, nāga sons, nāga daughters, great nāga ministers, nāga attendants, and nāga servants — those who approach with a mind of intense hostility, who follow along, who dwell together, who abide together, who rest together: these great sages are to be known as non-humans.

In villages and towns, those who show reverence or render honor — the great sage non-humans do not obtain access to such places. The royal palace called the Willow Palace has no ground or abiding place for them. The great sage non-humans and the yakṣas also do not obtain the right to dwell there together.

Furthermore, great sages, one must heed the commands of the non-humans. Furthermore, great sages, when non-humans bring complete benefit to oneself and then speak ill of others and engage in quarreling, and furthermore when non-humans place a blazing vessel upon someone's head, and furthermore when non-humans split someone's head into seven pieces — those great sage non-humans are fierce, violent, and wrathful.

They report in this manner to the great king. If they are unable to report to the great king, they report to his officers. If they are unable to report to the king's officers, they report to those officers' subordinates. Furthermore, great sages, those non-humans speak in opposition to the great king. Great sages, it is just as when a thief arises in the kingdom of Magadha: one reports it immediately to the king. If unable to report to the king, one reports to the king's officers. If unable to report to the officers, one reports to their subordinates — it is exactly like that.

Great sages, they also report to the king of Magadha that a thief has caused harm.

Great sages, such non-human beings as these are fierce, violent, and wrathful. They report at once to the great kings. If unable to report to the great kings, they report to the king's officers. If unable to report to the officers, they report to those officers' subordinates. Great sages, the non-humans report in opposition to the great kings in this way.

Great sages, whatever non-human being — whether a male yakṣa or a female yakṣa, a yakṣa's son or a yakṣa's daughter, a yakṣa's great minister, a yakṣa's retinue, or a yakṣa's attendant retinue; or a male gandharva or a female

gandharva, a gandharva's son or a gandharva's daughter, a gandharva's great minister, a gandharva's retinue, or a gandharva's attendant retinue; or a male kumbhāṇḍa or a female kumbhāṇḍa, a kumbhāṇḍa's son or a kumbhāṇḍa's daughter, a kumbhāṇḍa's great minister, a kumbhāṇḍa's retinue, or a kumbhāṇḍa's attendant retinue; or a male nāga or a female nāga, a nāga's son or a nāga's daughter, a nāga's great minister, a nāga's retinue, or a nāga's attendant retinue — with a mind of intense hatred pursues monks or nuns, male lay practitioners or female lay practitioners — following after them, or following along and dwelling with them, staying near them, resting alongside them — these beings petition the yakṣas and great yakṣas, the commanders and great commanders, and raise their voices and cry out loudly, saying: "Here in this place, seized by a yakṣa! This yakṣa takes life! This yakṣa inflicts harm! This yakṣa causes confusion! This yakṣa injures! This yakṣa causes grave injury! This yakṣa will not release them!"

As for who these yakṣas and great yakṣas, commanders and great commanders are:

Indra, Moon, Water-Moon,
Bharadvāja, lord of beings,
Candana, Highest Light,
Beautiful-Neck and Certain-Neck,
he who has become the guru of beings,
the helmsman born of the gods,
the many hosts of gandharvas,
Vijaya, finest of victorious herds,
likewise Hill and Snowbound,
Pleiades-Cave and Fullness,
Livelihood and Held-and-Released,
Varied-Friend and Yoke-Holder,
Earth-Protector and Fully-Discerning,
Modesty-Eye and House,
Fierce Five-Taker, Ālavaka,
Existence-Achiever, Good-Mind and Good-Face,
White-Face, Jewel and Jewel-User,
and likewise Īśvara and his company —

these all petition the yakṣas and great yakṣas, the commanders and great commanders, and raise their voices and cry out loudly, saying: "Here in this place, seized by a yakṣa! This yakṣa takes life! This yakṣa inflicts harm! This

yakṣa causes confusion! This yakṣa injures! This yakṣa causes grave injury! This yakṣa will not release them!"

Great sages, by this dhāraṇī let the palace of Jālavana be protected! Let monks and nuns, male lay practitioners and female lay practitioners be guarded, sheltered, kept free from harm, happy, and dwelling in peace.

Great sages, we must now depart.

We have many duties and many tasks to attend to.

The Blessed One declared: Great Kings, you may now depart.

Then the four Great Kings rose, paid homage to the Blessed One, circumambulated him, and vanished from that place. Those yakṣas likewise rose, and those among them who paid homage to the Blessed One and circumambulated him vanished from that very place. Those who had greeted the Blessed One with a respectful salutation and then asked about what is essential and what is not essential vanished from that very place. Those who had joined their palms together toward the Blessed One's presence vanished from that very place. Those who had examined names and lineages vanished from that very place. And those who had remained completely silent vanished from that very place.

This is the first supreme chapter of the Sūtra of the Palace of Jālavana.

Then, when that night had passed, the Blessed One summoned the monks and said: Monks, during this night the four Great Kings, the many great yakṣa commanders, the many hosts of gandharvas, the many hosts of kumbhāṇḍas, the many hosts of nāgas, guarded and dwelt in the four directions. They stayed in groups throughout the four directions. They protected and remained in the four directions. As the night drew on, beings of many colors illuminated Vulture Peak Mountain alone with their radiance, and came to where the Blessed One was; and having come, they paid homage to me and took their place to one side.

Monks, of those yakṣas, some paid homage to me and took their place to one side. Some greeted me with a respectful salutation and then inquired about what is essential and what is not essential, and took their place to one side. Some joined their palms together toward me and took their place to one side. Some examined names and lineages and took their place to one side. And some remained completely silent and took their place to one side.

When all had taken their place to one side, monks, the Great King Vaiśravaṇa addressed me with these words: Reverend Blessed One, there are disreputable yakṣas who have no faith in the Blessed One. There are also disreputable yakṣas who do have faith in the Blessed One. There are middling yakṣas who have no faith in the reverend Blessed One. There are middling yakṣas who have faith in the reverend Blessed One. There are inferior yakṣas who have no faith in the reverend Blessed One. There are inferior yakṣas who have faith in the reverend Blessed One.

What is the reason that certain yakṣas have no faith in the reverend Blessed One? It is because the reverend Blessed One has taught the Dharma of abandoning the taking of life, taught the Dharma of abandoning taking what is not given, taught the Dharma of abandoning sexual misconduct, taught the Dharma of abandoning false speech, and taught the Dharma of abandoning the drinking of intoxicants that lead to heedlessness. Those yakṣas who dislike the reverend Teacher's teachings on abandoning the taking of life, who dislike abandoning taking what is not given, who dislike abandoning sexual misconduct, who dislike abandoning false speech, and who dislike abandoning the drinking of intoxicants that lead to heedlessness — these are the ones who are displeased and unwilling.

Reverend Blessed One, all the śrāvakas that there are have entered into the paths of forest and wilderness retreats, lying down and sitting there. They abide in solitude, free from sound and noise, without the harm of company. The renunciants dwell in harmony among themselves.

There dwell in that place the abodes of malevolent yakṣas. Whosoever has lost faith in the Blessed One's word — in order to bring them to faith, Reverend Blessed One, let this be a training for you: I beg that the palace of Virūḍhaka protect them. Monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen abide there under protection, in concealment, free from harm, in ease and in good order. As for the monks, I grant this permission without speaking a word of it to them.

Then the Great King Vaiśravaṇa, knowing that permission had been granted, spoke at that very moment: Let them be protected by the palace of Virūḍhaka.

I bow to one who is endowed with eyes and endowed with glory,
to the All-Seer I bow in homage.

I bow to one who cherishes sentient beings,
to the Uṣṇīṣa-bearer I bow in homage.

I bow to one who consoles the unprotected,

to the Protector of All I bow in homage.
I bow to one who crushes the hosts of Māra,
to the Destroyer of Saṃsāra I bow in homage.
I bow to one endowed with the glory of a brahmin,
to the Golden Sage I bow in homage.
I bow to one who accomplishes the liberation of sentient beings,
to Kāśyapa I bow in homage.
The son of the Śākyas is endowed with glory —
I bow to the Solar Lineage.

To one who teaches the Dharma excellently,
liberating all beings from every suffering,
and who perceives whatever is worldly
exactly as it is —
before such a one there is no slander.
The great fearlessness
of one who pays homage to Gautama
is a benefit to gods and humans alike.
Endowed with knowledge and conduct,
such is the great fearlessness.

The great orb of the sun
sets and rises;
where the sun has set,
there night comes to be;
where the sun has risen,
there it is called day.
The essence of the waters of the deep ocean
is excellent;
one born there in that way
is like the essence of the ocean's water.

Here, to the beings of the eastern quarter, this is proclaimed:
The Great King of renown, who guards that direction —
lord of the gandharvas (celestial musicians),
whose name is King Dhṛtarāṣṭra —
together with his retinue of gandharvas
takes delight in song and dance.
His many sons all bear a single name:

they are called Indra, endowed with power,
and they number ninety-one.
They too, upon seeing the Buddha,
upon seeing the Buddha of the Solar Lineage,
bow from afar
to the Great One free from fear.
O Knower of all beings, to you I bow!
O Supreme Being, to you I bow!
To you who ever teach what is virtuous,
you whom the non-humans venerate —
to you I ever listen.
Therefore it is proclaimed thus:
Pay homage to the Victor Gautama!
I pay homage to the Victor Gautama!
Endowed with knowledge and conduct —
to the Victor Gautama I bow in homage.

Whoever speaks as hungry ghosts do,
who bears the flesh of slander on his back,
who is attached to taking life,
and who destroys all beings without exception —

Here, to the beings who dwell in the southern quarter, this is proclaimed:
The Great King of renown, who guards that abode —
lord of the kumbhāṇḍas (a class of spirits),
whose name is Virūḍhaka —
together with his retinue of kumbhāṇḍas
takes delight in song and dance.
His many sons all bear a single name:
they are called Indra, endowed with power,
and they number ninety-one.
They too, upon seeing the Buddha,
upon seeing the Buddha of the Solar Lineage,
bow from afar
to the Great One free from fear.
O Knower of all beings, to you I bow!
O Supreme Being, to you I bow!
To you who ever teach what is virtuous,

you whom the non-humans venerate —
to you I ever listen.

Therefore it is proclaimed thus:

Bow to the Victor Gautama!

We bow to the Victor Gautama!

Endowed with knowledge and with feet of conduct,
we pay homage to the Buddha Gautama.

Wherever the great orb of the sun
has risen from one place to another,
there it becomes daytime —
and that is what is called the day.

Wherever the sun has set,
there it is spoken of as night.

As the excellent essence of the waters
of the deep and fathomless ocean,
so too, born there in the very same way,
it is like the essence of the ocean's waters.

Here now, to the people of the western quarter,
this is proclaimed:

The great and greatly renowned king
who guards that quarter,
lord over the nāgas,
whose name is Virūpākṣa —
together with his retinue of nāgas
takes delight in song and dance.

His many sons all bear a single name:
they are called Indra, endowed with power,
and they number ninety-one.

They too, upon seeing the Buddha,
upon seeing the Buddha of the Solar Lineage,
bow from afar
to the Great One free from fear.

O Knower of all beings, to you I bow!

O Supreme Being, to you I bow!

To you who ever teach what is virtuous,
you whom the non-humans venerate —

to you I ever listen.

Therefore it is proclaimed thus:

Bow to the Victor Gautama!

We bow to the Victor Gautama!

Endowed with knowledge and with feet of conduct,
we pay homage to the Buddha Gautama.

As for the northern quarter — the land of Śrāvastī —
the beautiful mountain of delight,
the people born there
hold nothing as their own.

They sow no seeds,
nor do they plough the earth.
Without toil, fruits ripen of themselves,
and people enjoy them in abundance.

Husked grain, pure and very clean,
fragrant rice bearing its fruit —
they churn its milk
and likewise cook it and enjoy it.

Riding a single-legged ox,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounted on a one-legged beast,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounting a woman's conveyance,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounting a man's conveyance,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounting a maiden's conveyance,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounting a youth's conveyance,
they travel from land to land and region to region.

Mounting all those conveyances,
they follow every direction.

The chief king is without equal.

Mounted on elephant conveyances, on horse conveyances,
and dwelling in divine conveyances,
in fine mansions and in galleries,

is the great and greatly renowned king.
And his completed city
dwells in the stainless sky:
the city of Lāṅgalin, the city of Kuśa,
the city beyond of Kuśa,
the city of Nāṭā and the city beyond
that is Kuśita.

In the north, all flourish;
many gathered multitudes dwell there.
Ninety-nine sky-cities,
and the royal palace Lāṅgalin.

Again, the great sage
and the great king Virūpākṣa —
the palace of the great king is called Cogaldan.
Therefore the great king is spoken of as Vaiśravaṇa's son and as Virūpākṣa.

Separately distinguished and at peace, possessing in each case this and that
radiance and this and that majesty, brave and endowed with power — this is
the name of a king endowed with power.

The earth too is full of essence.
In that place the clouds send down their rain.
There is the pond called Bhagalavātī,
where the host of yakṣas dwells together.

There, always, fruits of trees,
and many varied birds dwell together:
peacocks and cranes cry out,
and cuckoos dwell in flocks.
Śaṅkha-birds and owls cry out;
and there also the osprey
and the jungle-hen and forest crows
dwell in the forest pool.

The parrot and the red-bellied cuckoo cry out, and the white dandamānabya
birds make the place beautiful at all times. The pond of the King Luṅgan is
ever lovely.

This is the region of the northern quarter, as people describe it. The great king who guards that quarter is renowned, and he is the lord of the yakṣas. His name is Luṅgan. He and his retinue of yakṣas delight in song and dance.

His many sons all share a single name that one hears spoken: they are called Indra, endowed with power. They number ninety-one.

And they, upon seeing a buddha, and upon seeing the buddha who is kinsman of the sun, bow from afar to the one who is utterly free from fear. "Homage to you, man of complete knowledge! Homage to you, most excellent of men! To you who ever speak of virtue, homage from the non-human ones, who always listen to this" — and for that reason they speak thus: "Pay homage to the Victor Gautama! We pay homage to the Victor Gautama! Endowed with wisdom and with perfect conduct, homage to the buddha Gautama!"

Here let the great sage with the willow grove protect them: monks and nuns, laymen and laywomen are guarded, sheltered, unharmed, and dwell in comfort and well-being. Whichever great sages accompany monks, or nuns, or laymen, or laywomen — let them, together with the palace of the willow grove, guard those persons and embrace them completely in their entirety.

Now these are the non-humans: yakṣas male and female, sons and daughters of yakṣas, great ministers of yakṣas, the retinue of yakṣas, and the servants of yakṣas; gandharvas (dri za) male and female, their sons and daughters, their great ministers, their retinue, and their servants; kumbhāṇḍas (grulbum) male and female, their sons and daughters, their great ministers, their retinue, and their servants; nāgas male and female, their sons and daughters, their great ministers, their retinue, and their servants — all those who, with a mind of hostility, come and go, follow after others, sit or sit alongside others, dwell or dwell alongside others, lie down or lie down alongside others. Great sage, these are what are called non-humans.

Those in towns or villages who pay them honor or make offerings to them — great sage, those non-humans are not to be approached by them. There is no place or abode called the palace of the Great King with the Willow Grove. Those non-humans will not obtain dwelling alongside the yakṣas, great sage, or approach them.

Great sage, the non-humans are further to be obeyed. And further, great sage, the non-humans completely benefit oneself while disparaging and quarreling with others; and, great sage, the non-humans again are those who place a blazing vessel upon their heads and, great sage, the non-humans cause heads

to split into seven pieces. Great sage, the non-humans further are fierce, violent, and wrathful. These are what they declare to the great king. If they are unable to declare it to the great king, they declare it to a person or others of that sort.

If they are unable to declare it to a person of the great king, they declare it to the person below that one. And further, great sage, the non-humans speak words that are contrary to the king. Great sage, it is like this: if a thief arises in the land of Magadha, they immediately declare it to the king. If they are unable to declare it to the king, they declare it to a person of the king. If they are unable to declare it to that person, they declare it to the person below that one, just as before. Great sage, in the same way, they report to the king of Magadha that a thief is causing harm. Great sage, those non-humans of this kind are fierce, violent, and wrathful. They immediately declare it to the great kings. If they are unable to declare it to the great kings, they declare it to a person of the king. If they are unable to declare it to that person, they declare it to the person below that one. Great sage, the non-humans declare words contrary to the great kings.

Great sage, whatever non-human — whether a male yakṣa or a female yakṣa, a yakṣa son or a yakṣa daughter, a great yakṣa minister, a yakṣa retinue, or a yakṣa attendant retinue; a male gandharva or a female gandharva, a gandharva son or a gandharva daughter, a great gandharva minister, a gandharva retinue, or a gandharva attendant retinue; a male kumbhāṇḍa or a female kumbhāṇḍa, a kumbhāṇḍa son or a kumbhāṇḍa daughter, a great kumbhāṇḍa minister, a kumbhāṇḍa retinue, or a kumbhāṇḍa attendant retinue; a male nāga or a female nāga, a nāga son or a nāga daughter, a great nāga minister, a nāga retinue, or a nāga attendant retinue — any of these, with a mind of intense hatred, whether monks or nuns, laymen or laywomen, who are going about, or following, or staying and remaining together, or lying down and lying down together: these make supplications to the yakṣas, the great yakṣas, the yakṣa chieftains, and the great yakṣa chieftains; they howl and cry out and roar loudly. There, seized by a yakṣa, that yakṣa takes away the life, that yakṣa causes harm, that yakṣa causes confusion, that yakṣa causes injury, that yakṣa causes grave injury, and that yakṣa does not release them.

Who then are the yakṣas, the great yakṣas, the yakṣa chieftains, and the great yakṣa chieftains? They are as follows:

Indra (Śakra, king of the gods), Moon-water-moon,
Bhāradvāja, lord of creatures,
Candana, Best-Desire,
Beautiful-Neck and Certain-Neck,
the preeminent one among creatures,
the helmsman born from the gods,
the various hosts of gandharvas,
the supreme herd victorious over humans,
likewise Mountain and Snowy-Peak,
Full, Pleiades-Cave,
Harm and Holding-and-Grasping,
Various-Friend who holds the yoke,
the Earth-Guardian who is supremely wise,
Shame-Eye and House,
Five-Taking, Fierce, Ālpaka,
Existence-Accomplishing, Good-Mind, Good-Face,
Curd-Face, Jewel, Jewel-User,
and likewise Maheśvara and his company.

These make supplications to the yakṣas, the great yakṣas, the yakṣa chieftains, and the great yakṣa chieftains; they howl and cry out and roar loudly. There, seized by a yakṣa, that yakṣa takes away the life, that yakṣa causes harm, that yakṣa causes confusion, that yakṣa causes injury,

that yakṣa causes grievous harm, and that yakṣa does not release. May the great sage protect with the Palace of the Willow Grove! For monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen there is protection, shelter, freedom from harm, and they dwell in happiness and well-being. Great sage, we must now depart. We have many duties and many things to do. Monks, I now grant the four great kings permission to go. Then the four great kings rose, paid homage to me, circumambulated, and vanished on the spot. Monks, the yakṣas too rose, paid homage to me, circumambulated, and vanished on the spot. Those who had reported their illness to me, and having reported it had inquired how to distinguish the essential from the non-essential, they vanished on the spot. Those who had joined their palms toward me in that direction and made obeisance vanished on the spot. Some, having examined names and lineages, vanished on the spot. Some became silent and vanished on the spot.

Monks, hold this by heart, and may the Palace of the Willow Grove protect! Monks, chant it with earnest longing, and may the Palace of the Willow Grove

protect! Monks, hold it with full meaning, and may the Palace of the Willow Grove protect! For monks and nuns, for laymen and laywomen, there is protection, shelter, freedom from harm, and they dwell in happiness and well-being.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught. The second supreme chapter — the Sūtra of the Palace of the Willow Grove is complete.

From before the presence of the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī, the learned translator, the Śākya monk Nyi ma rgyal mtshan dpal bzang po, translated and edited this at the great seat of those learned in two languages, the glorious monastery of Thar pa gling.

Translator's Notes

- The term rendered as "kumbhāṇḍas" refers to a class of supernatural beings, here listed alongside yakṣas, gandharvas, and nāgas as troops attending the four great kings. The Tibetan transliteration "grul bum" reflects the Sanskrit kumbhāṇḍa directly.

The phrase about yakṣas inquiring about "matters of substance and matters without substance" renders a traditional formula that may refer to meaningful versus idle conversation, or alternatively to the essential versus the inessential in Dharma discussion. The doctrinal import is not entirely settled by context alone.

The opening verse at the end is terse and compressed, functioning as a salutation to Vaiśravaṇa himself or to the Blessed One; the referent of "the All-Seeing" in this immediate context is ambiguous and may refer to Vaiśravaṇa paying homage to the Blessed One as he begins his recitation.

- The phrase rendered "endowed with knowledge and feet" translates a standard epithet of the Buddha, vidyācaraṇasampanna in Sanskrit, meaning one perfect in both wisdom-knowledge and conduct. This somewhat opaque epithet is preserved literally in keeping with the formulaic liturgical character of the text.

The figure named Kāśyapa, glossed here as "Kṣitigarbha" in the house glossary under སྐྱིལ་ཁ་པ་, is actually Kāśyapa Buddha, one of the seven buddhas of antiquity, here praised as the one who liberated sentient beings. The Tibetan སྐྱིལ་ཁ་པ་ is the standard rendering of Kāśyapa in this context.

The line rendered "who has flesh of slander upon his back" is a traditional idiom for a slanderer; the image is that backbiting speech clings to the slanderer like flesh on one's back.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the given Tibetan, consistent with the text continuing in a subsequent passage.

- The passage transitions from the western quarter's description (Virūpākṣa as lord of nāgas, per the prior passage) to the northern quarter. Textually, the same name Virūpākṣa appears as lord of yakṣas in the north, which is unusual — traditionally Vaiśravaṇa guards the north and rules the yakṣas, while Virūpākṣa guards the west and rules the nāgas. The Tibetan text itself assigns Virūpākṣa to the north here, and also names Vaiśravaṇa parenthetically ("son of Vaiśravaṇa"). This reflects a textual tradition that may differ from the standard Pāli fourfold

arrangement, and has been rendered faithfully as the text stands.

The bird names śaṅkhatera, ngurpa, gonmo, and daṇḍamāṭa are transliterated; these are Tibetan phonetic renderings of bird names whose Sanskrit originals are uncertain or unidentifiable with confidence.

The phrase "single-footed ox" or "single-footed beast" is a standard cosmological feature of the Uttarakuru northern continent description, where animals serve as vehicles and rice grows without cultivation — a paradise topos in Buddhist cosmology.

- "Kinsman of the sun" is a well-known epithet of the Buddha as a Śākya, since the Śākya clan claimed solar lineage; Sanskrit sūryavamśa / ādityabandhu.

The phrase rendered "great sages" throughout this prose section translates *drang srong chen po*, which literally means "great ṛṣis." In this cosmological-protective *sūtra* context the term refers to the assembly of spiritually powerful beings (monks, nuns, and lay practitioners under the protection of Virūpākṣa); the usage is somewhat unusual and may reflect a technical term of this particular text tradition.

The term rendered "willow palace" (lca ng lo can gyi pho brang) is the name of Virūpākṣa's palace, literally "the palace of the one who has willows" or "the willow-bearing palace," associated with the northern quarter.

The numbering "ninety-one" for the sons called Indra follows directly from the preceding passage's narrative about Virūpākṣa's sons all sharing one name; the precise significance of ninety-one in this context is a feature of the sūtra's cosmological enumeration.

- The verse section contains a list of yakṣa and related non-human names, many of which are proper names in Sanskrit transliteration rendered phonetically in Tibetan. Several are transparent (Bharadvāja, Ālavaka, Īśvara), while others such as "Moon," "Water-Moon," "Beautiful-Neck," "Certain-Neck," "Snowbound," "Pleiades-Cave," "Livelihood," "Held-and-Released," "Modesty-Eye," "Fierce Five-Taker," and so forth are rendered by their Tibetan semantic equivalents. Identification of precise Sanskrit originals for all names in this verse list is uncertain; the renderings given follow the literal Tibetan meanings as faithfully as possible.

The term "kumbhāṇḍa" (कुम्भाण्ड) refers to a class of non-human beings, pot-bellied spirits in the Indian cosmological schema, retained in Sanskrit here for clarity.

"The palace of Jālavana" renders जालवनाद्वयमालयालयः, literally "the palace of the one with willow leaves," a known vaksa abode; jālavana is the standard Sanskrit reconstruction.

- The phrase rendered "greeted the Blessed One with a respectful salutation" translates 問訊如來, which literally means "to inquire after the health" or "to pay one's respects with a formal greeting." In this context it functions as a polite salutation formula preceding a question, here about what is "essential and what is not essential" (要法與不要法), likely meaning the substantial versus the insubstantial, or the meaningful versus the meaningless in practice.

The term कम्भान्दस rendered here as kumbhāṇḍas follows the standard identification of this class of beings (Skt. kumbhāṇḍa); they are a class of spirits associated with the southern direction in the four Great Kings' cosmology.

- The verse section contains a set of epithets that function as a liturgical hymn of praise. "Uṣṇīṣa-bearer" renders the Tibetan gtsug tor can, referring to the cranial protuberance, a major mark of a buddha. "Golden Sage" renders gser thub, which may be a rendering of Skt. Kanakamuni, one of the past buddhas; similarly, Kāśyapa named in the next verse is another of the seven buddhas of antiquity. The passage then pivots into prose before returning to verse

for the directional guardian section.

The phrase "bears the flesh of slander on his back" renders a Tibetan idiom for a back-biter or slanderer.

The four Great Kings and their associated spirit classes follow the canonical schema of the *Āṭānāṭīya Sūtra*. Dhṛtarāṣṭra governs the east with gandharvas; Virūḍhaka governs the south with kumbhāṇḍas. The text is clearly excerpting this well-known sūtra.

- The passage on the northern quarter describes a mythic land of natural abundance, likely corresponding to Uttarakuru, the northern continent in Buddhist cosmology, though it is not named as such in this passage. The "single-legged ox" and the various conveyances described are standard features of Uttarakuru mythology in early Buddhist texts.

The city names — Lāṅgalin, Kuśa, Nāṭā, Kuśita, and the palace Cogaldan — are transliterations of Tibetan phonetic renderings of Indian place or mythic city names and are retained as close transliterations since firm Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain.

The guardian of the western quarter is Virūpākṣa (Tibetan: mig mi bzang, literally "ill-eyed" or "deformed-eyed"), lord of the nāgas, which is doctrinally consistent with the standard four great kings (caturmahārāja) cosmology. The guardian of the north is Vaiśravaṇa (Tibetan: rnam thos kyi bu), lord of the yakṣas.

The phrase rendered "Endowed with knowledge and with feet of conduct" reflects the standard epithet "vijjācaraṇasampanna" (Pali) / "vidyācaraṇasampanna" (Sanskrit), meaning possessed of both knowledge and right conduct — a classical epithet of the Buddha.

The section beginning "Separately distinguished and at peace..." is a difficult syntactic run-on in the Tibetan, likely a corrupted or formulaic passage listing royal epithets. The rendering conveys the sense without imposing false clarity.

- The passage preserves a dhāraṇī-sūtra style catalogue, reminiscent of the *Āṭānāṭīya-sūtra* tradition, listing the yakṣa king of the north (here rendered Luṅgan from Luṅgan-po, likely corresponding to Vaiśravaṇa or a subordinate yakṣa king in a northern-quarter invocation), his ninety-one sons named Indra (dbang-po), and a protective formula covering the four assemblies. The phrase "kinsman of the sun" renders nyi ma'i gnyen, a standard epithet for the Buddha as a Śākya, since the Śākyas claimed solar lineage. The "blazing vessel placed on the head" and "splitting the head into seven pieces" are standard formulaic threats in dhāraṇī protective literature, signifying the supernatural punishment non-humans may inflict on those who violate the compact. The precise identification of some bird names in the opening verse (dandamānabya) relies on Sanskrit loan-transcription and remains uncertain; they appear to name specific Indic bird species now difficult to identify exactly.

- The verse section listing the names of yakṣa chieftains presents the most significant challenge in this passage. These are proper names of yakṣas and spirit-beings, many of which are Tibetan transcriptions or translations of Sanskrit names that are not easily recoverable. The rendering here follows the most plausible interpretation of each name as a descriptive epithet or transliteration: "Moon-water-moon" for Dbang-po Zla-ba Chu-zla, "Bhāradvāja" retained as a Sanskrit name preserved in the Tibetan, and the remaining names rendered as literal translations of the Tibetan where no Sanskrit original is certain. The name "Ālpaka" appears to be a direct Tibetan transcription of a Sanskrit or Prakrit name. Scholars working with the Sanskrit parallel of this text would be needed to confirm the precise names. The passage breaks off mid-sentence as given, consistent with a text continuation.

- The phrase rendered "hold this by heart" translates a term meaning to retain or memorize by recitation; the threefold injunction that follows uses three different verbs of uptake: memorizing by recitation, earnest chanting, and holding with full understanding of meaning,

which represent a graduated formula of textual transmission common in sūtra literature.

The colophon names the translator as Nyi ma rgyal mtshan dpal bzang po, a Śākya monk, working from the oral guidance of the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī at Thar pa gling monastery, described as a great seat for those conversant in two languages, meaning Sanskrit and Tibetan.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.